

Issues and Questions of Multiple Sclerosis Patients

based on Interviews and
Comprehensive Research

Objective of the report

The objective of the report is to present the areas in the multiple sclerosis patient pathway that cause the greatest difficulties and require more attention, as well as to identify the questions and doubts that MS patients have most frequently.

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1. **Research approach**

Research Objective

Primary question:



What are the potential areas where patients diagnosed with Multiple Sclerosis (MS) can be supported or enhanced by AI?

I wanted to answer this question in order to:



identify the specific fields where the project can provide **the most significant impact** and support for patients



deepen my understanding through examples of how AI can assist patients, and identify potential risks and challenges



determine the exact ways in which our project can deliver tangible benefits to the target audience.

Interview

Who did I interview?

Interviews were carried out with experts from Roche, who provided their professional perspectives on Neurology (focusing on MS), AI, and Communication



Each interview lasted between **45 and 60 minutes**



I spoke with **13 experts**



Experts work in:

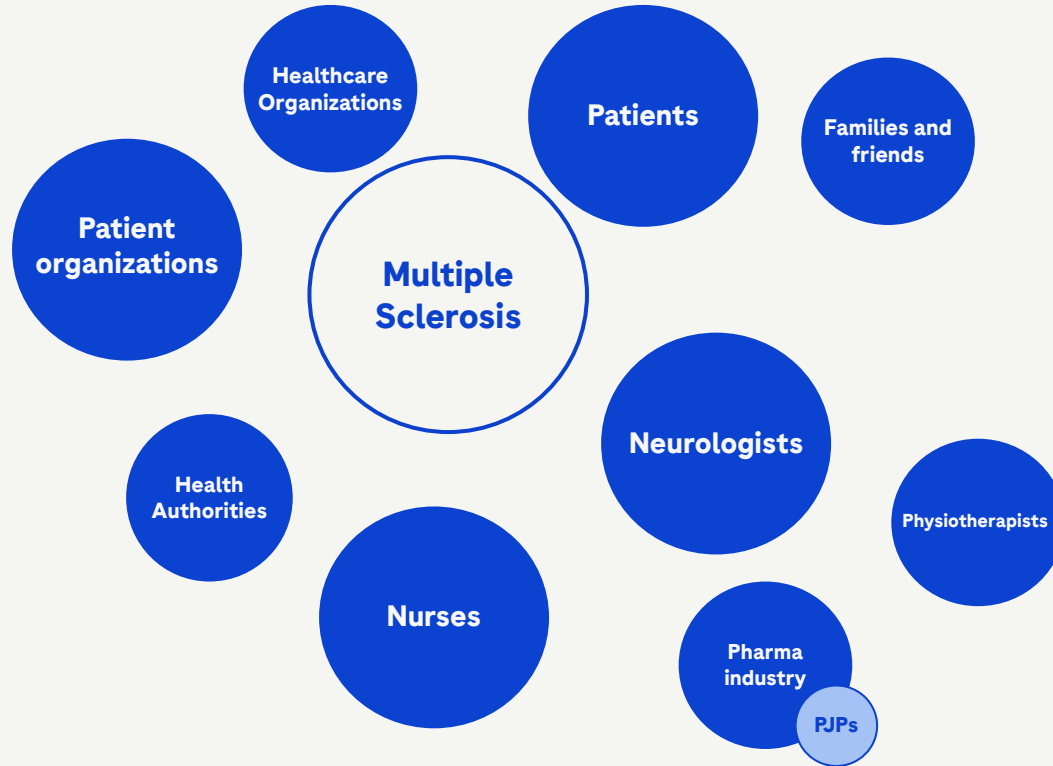
- Communication
- UX
- Artificial Intelligence
- Neurology
 - Multiple Sclerosis
 - Relations with patient organizations
 - The “Neurozmobilizowani” campaign

2.

Interview Insights

Neurology

Multiple Sclerosis Stakeholder Map



The speed of the diagnosis

Relapsing MS

Usually a direct path

A relapse e.g. sudden vision loss, numbness is an sudden event that cannot be ignored.

Because the symptoms are alarming, patients often head straight to SOR.

Doctors **recognize the neurological crisis quickly**, and the diagnosis is confirmed within days.

Progressive MS

Finding a neurologist and accessing specific specialists is often a major hurdle.

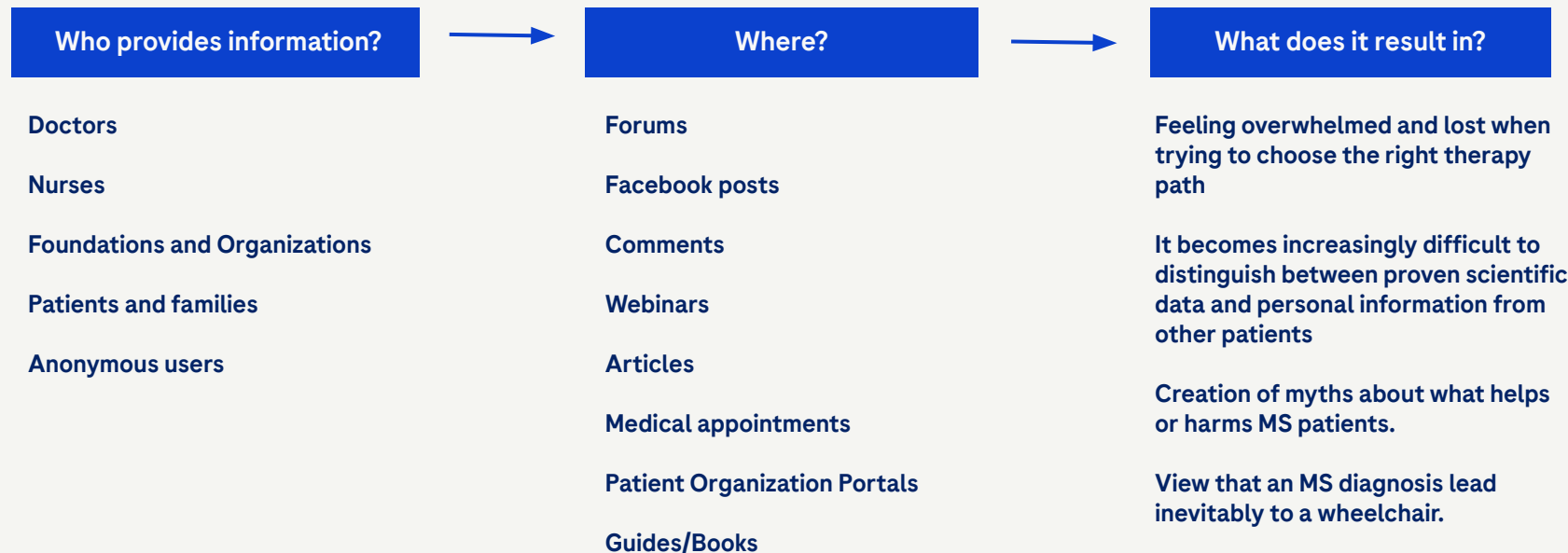
It starts with minor issues that are ignored.

Because there is no sudden attack, patients often start at their Primary Care Physician (GP). Since the symptoms are non-specific, they are often misdiagnosed.

Patients are shuffled to various specialists. **It can take years to finally get the right diagnosis (MS).**

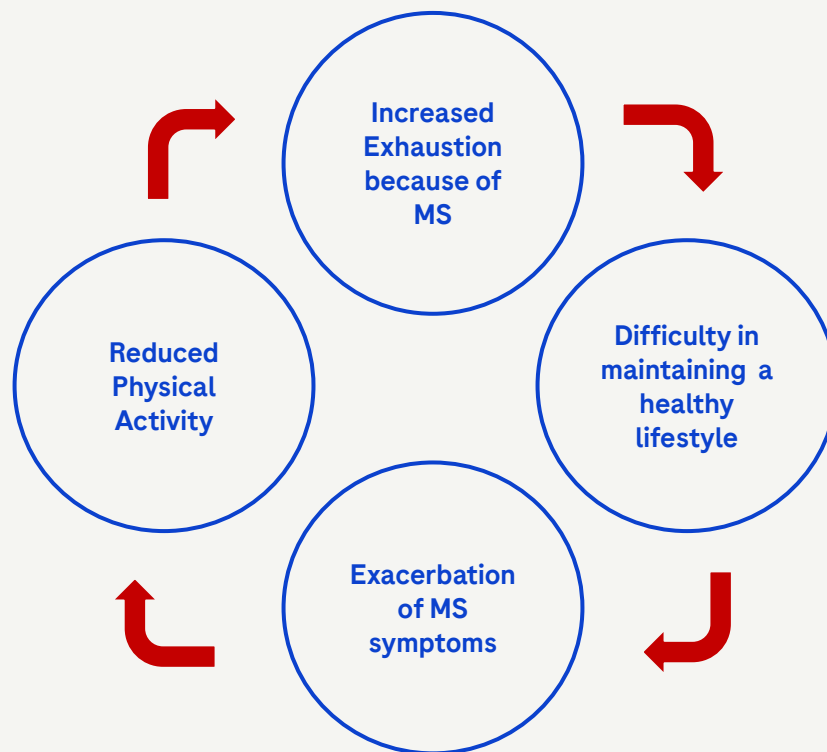
Information chaos

as a problem of patients during diagnosis



Cycle of MS Progression

According to experts' interviews



The Treatment

Difficulties during the treatment process



1. When **selecting a therapy**, patients are overwhelmed by the information chaos

Side effects can feel more harmful than the long-term benefits of the drug.

Rushed clinical visits leave little room for the deep education needed to make such a life-changing decision

2. After a decision is made, information chaos threatens **long-term success of the therapy**

When symptoms disappear, sometimes patients mistakenly feel cured and stop treatment

Social media narratives and **unverified personal stories** often carry more weight than medical facts.

Without proper psychological support, patients feel isolated in their doubts, leading to inconsistent therapy.

Mental Challenges for MS Patients

According to experts' interviews



1. It's very difficult for patients to deal with how much their life has changed. They often feel a **sense of loss**, constantly comparing their current physical struggles to how they used to be before the diagnosis.
2. Patients may feel **embarrassed by mobility issues**, which hits their self-confidence and can easily lead to deeper problems like depression.
3. They struggle with an **anxiety about the future** (e.g. losing the ability to move) which results from beliefs such as the "wheelchair myth".
4. Patients often choose to **keep their MS a secret** from friends or colleagues. They do this to feel like a regular person, but it's exhausting and stops them from getting the emotional support they actually need.

Levels of Patient Trust and Openness

According to experts' interviews

Nurses

high trust

Patients often feel **more comfortable** sharing "embarrassing" symptoms or **sensitive details** with nurses (rather than doctors). Perceived as more empathetic listeners.

Doctors

formal

Rare and short clinical visits make **detailed interviews impossible**; consequently, subtle changes in symptoms are difficult to detect.

Patients often withhold small updates, fearing they are wasting the doctor's **limited time** or that their symptoms aren't "serious enough" for a formal visit.

Influencers

relatable

Shared **personal experiences**. Patients feel a close connection to influencers who discuss their own health journeys, making the medical advice or experiences feel more **human and accessible**.

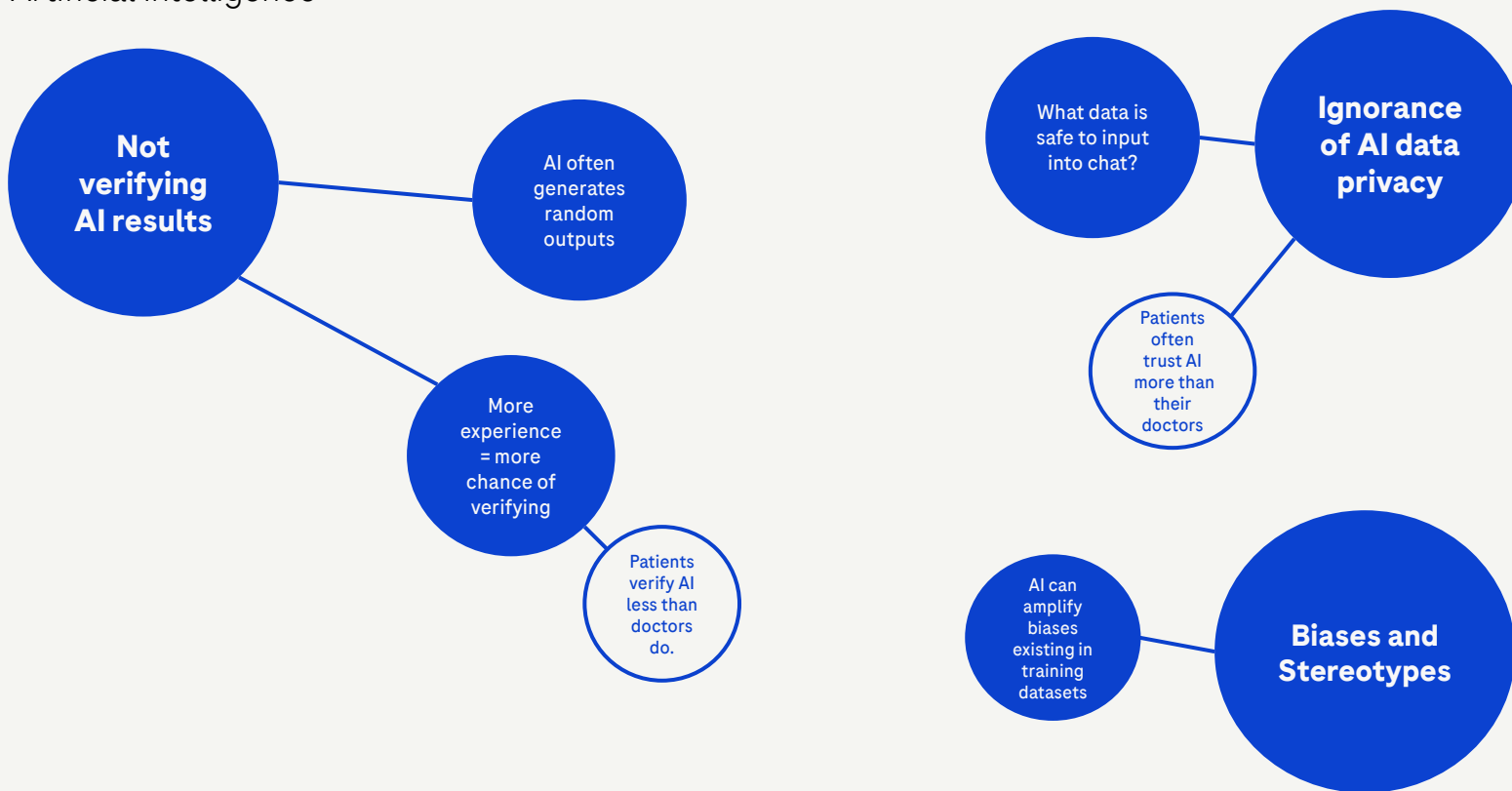
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Interview Insights

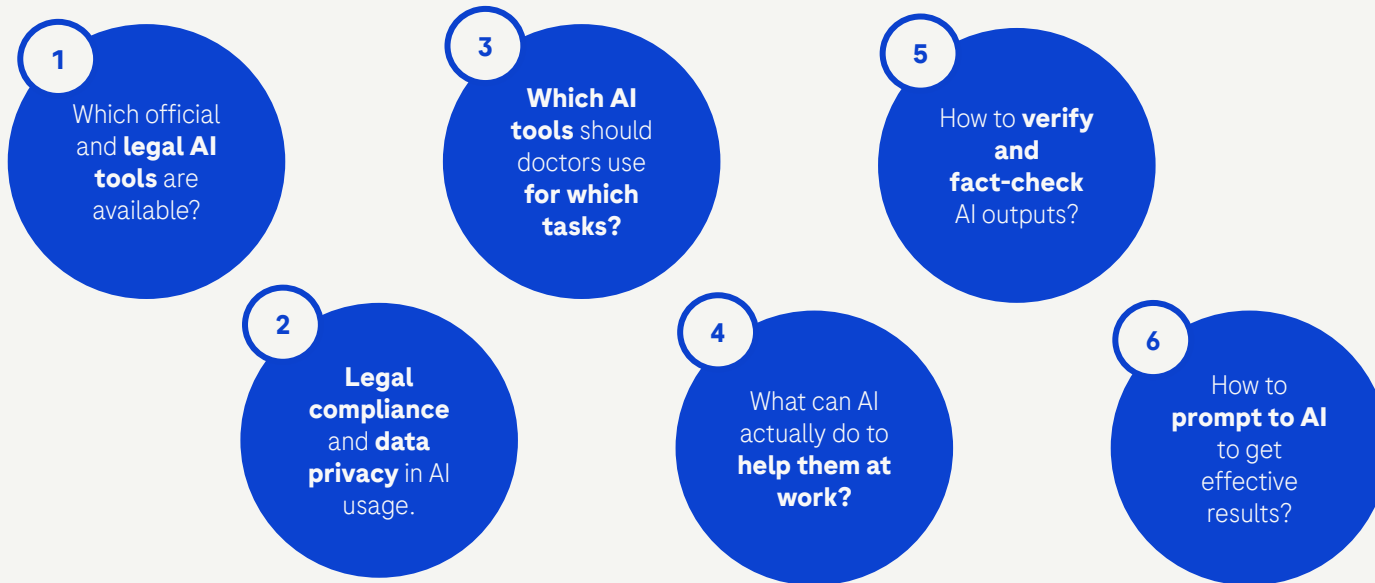
Artificial Intelligence

Main problems and areas worth improving

Artificial Intelligence



What Doctors Want to Know About AI ?



AI gives us many opportunities as well!



Advanced analysis of medical imaging, disease progression, and treatment history



Translating medical terminology into language that patients can easily understand



Automated pre-filling of medical records and allowing doctors to focus more on patient interaction



Simplified structuring of medical records and interviews

4.

Next steps

Additional insights

More diverse group = Better results

(conclusion from Datathon)

Anything produced by a computer is wrong until proven otherwise

Simple tools can be more effective than the complex ones (when it comes to project management)

Sometimes we feel like we are making progress just because we are talking about a topic. However, without clear, documented agreements and next steps, there is no real progress.

Thank you for your time!